

WHEN YOUR BABY HAS JAUNDICE

Jaundice in newborns is so common that it's more unusual if your baby doesn't develop this condition.

It is caused by a buildup in the blood of a yellow substance called bilirubin, which causes the skin and the whites of the eyes to turn pale yellow. All newborn babies can tolerate mild jaundice and monitoring is all that is needed. It tends to clear up naturally within two weeks, and just 1 in 20 babies needs treatment (see p.322).



Jaundiced babies Jaundice improves quickly and often babies don't need treatment.

SPOTS AND RASHES

Your baby may be born with a cluster of tiny, white spots over her nose, cheeks, eyes, and forehead, or these may develop in the early weeks. These are known as milia, and are thought to be caused by underdeveloped glands in the skin. They are harmless and will disappear within a few weeks.

GENITALS

A surge in maternal hormones just before the birth means that both girls and boys may be born with swollen breasts and genitals from the hormones crossing over the placenta. Girls may have a vaginal discharge, which may even have a little blood in it, and there may be a white discharge from the breasts. All of this is normal, and the swelling will die down in the first few days.

BIRTHMARKS

Marks on the skin at birth are common and are usually nothing to worry about. Birthmarks fall into two categories: vascular or pigmented. Vascular birthmarks include:

BIRTHMARK	LOOKS LIKE	DESCRIPTION
Stork marks		Stork marks are also called salmon patches or nevus simplex. These light pink marks can appear on the forehead, the nose, around the mouth, on the eyelids, or the nape of the neck. These usually fade over time until they are hardly noticeable.
Strawberry hemangiomas		These are harmless, raised red marks formed by a concentration of immature blood vessels. They can grow quickly in the first few months, then start to shrink back and disappear. Depending on their size and position, they sometimes require treatment.
Port-wine stains		Port-wine stains, also called nevus flammeus, are flat, red or purple marks caused by a concentration of dilated blood vessels. They darken over time and are permanent. They can appear anywhere on the body, but are usually on the face, neck, or the limbs.

PIGMENTED BIRTHMARKS

Café au lait spots		These coffee-colored patches can appear anywhere on the body. They may be present at birth, and more may appear over the first years of life. While usually harmless, if your child has several, it's worth asking the doctor to have a quick look.
Mongolian blue spots		Mongolian spots are more common on darker-skinned babies. These blue-gray patches of skin typically appear on the back or buttocks, and usually fade on their own in the first few years.
Moles		Known as congenital nevi, these are brown or black, and can be flat or raised. These marks are usually harmless, but should be monitored since they carry a risk of becoming malignant later in life.

HANDS AND FEET

Your baby's legs may be "bowed" and her feet curved inward, reflecting the curled up position she adopted in the uterus. Her limbs and feet will straighten out over time. If your baby was full term, her toes and fingernails may be quite long, and she may even have managed to scratch herself. The nails will be soft, so you can peel them off very carefully or clip them with baby scissors.

Umbilical cord The clamped cord will fall off naturally around 10 days after birth.